

Vendor Catalogue — User Guide

TechPIO Services LLP

Prepared by Harry Singh · +91 98768 19230 · Version 1.1 · 7 September 2026

1. What the Vendor Catalogue is for

Before this, buying a laptop worked like this: somebody raised a request, somebody else phoned two or three suppliers, wrote the prices on paper or in WhatsApp, and then decided. The price nobody wrote down was forgotten. The reason for choosing the costlier supplier was forgotten even faster.

The Vendor Catalogue puts all of that inside PioAssets:

- Suppliers list what they are selling, at what price, **until which date**
- The system works out the **landed cost** — the real all-inclusive price per unit
- You say what you need, and every offer is checked against it
- When you choose one, the price and specification are **frozen as proof**

Everything in this guide is in Rupees, and every figure shown is worked out step by step so you can check it by hand.

2. The five pieces, in plain words

Piece	In one line
Vendor	The supplier company — Dell, Lenovo, a local dealer
Offer	One product, at one price, valid until one date
Spec template	The questions a type of item is described by (RAM, weight, warranty)
Comparison	Checking every offer against what you actually need
Selection	Choosing one offer, and freezing the proof

They are used in that order. A spec template is set up once for a category, then every offer in that category answers the same questions — which is the only reason comparison is possible at all.

3. Spec templates — the questions an item is described by

What it is

A **spec template** is simply the list of things you care about when buying that kind of item. For laptops you care about RAM, storage and weight. For office chairs you do not — you care about material, adjustment and warranty.

It is set up under **Settings** → **Spec templates** by Office Admin, Finance, Procurement Manager, IT Admin or Super Admin.

Category or type

Your items sit in categories (*IT Assets*) and types within them (*Laptop, Monitor, Mouse*). A question can be attached at either level, and choosing correctly is what stops the template becoming nonsense:

- **Attached to a type** — RAM belongs to *Laptop*. A mouse is never asked it.
- **Left at category level** — warranty type belongs to *IT Assets*, because every one of them has one.

Why it matters

Without a template, two suppliers describe the same laptop in two different ways and nobody can compare them:

Without a template

Supplier A writes: "*i5, 16GB, 512 SSD, light weight*"

Supplier B writes: "*Intel Core i5 13th gen, 16 GB DDR5, 512 GB, 1.4 kg*"

Both may be fine. But you cannot line them up side by side, and you certainly cannot let the computer do it for you.

With a template, both suppliers fill in the *same boxes*, and comparison becomes possible.

Setting one up

This is the template in use today for **IT Assets** → **Laptop**:

Field	Kind	Unit	Which way it points	Required
RAM	Number	GB	At least	Yes
Storage	Number	GB	At least	Yes
Processor	Text	—	—	Yes
Screen size	Number	inch	At least	No
Weight	Number	kg	At most	No
Operating system	List	—	5 choices	No
Backlit keyboard	Yes / No	—	—	No

The one setting people get wrong

Look carefully at **"Which way it points"**. This is the most important box on the whole screen.

Why it matters

When you ask for **16 GB RAM**, you mean *"16 or more"*. A supplier offering 32 GB has given you something better.

When you ask for **1.5 kg weight**, you mean *"1.5 or less"*. A supplier offering 2.4 kg has given you something worse — but the number is bigger.

If Weight is set to "At least" by mistake, the system will happily tell you a 2.4 kg laptop beats a 1.2 kg one. The comparison would be exactly backwards, and it would look perfectly normal on screen.

This is why PioAssets refuses to save a Number field until you say which way it points. There is no default, on purpose.

Required fields

Tick **Required** on the things you will not buy without knowing. A supplier cannot send an offer for review until every required field is filled in.

This is kinder to the supplier than it sounds. A blank field counts as *"Not stated"* during comparison, and *"Not stated" fails* — so an incomplete offer would quietly lose. Better to stop it early and let them fix it.

Tolerance

Optional. It says how close is *close enough* to be worth a human look.

Example — RAM required 16 GB, tolerance 0.1 (that is 10%)

- Offered 16 GB → **Pass**
- Offered 32 GB → **Pass** (shows as "Exceeds")
- Offered 15 GB → **Partial** — 6% short. A person decides.
- Offered 8 GB → **Fail** — 50% short, not a close call.

Leave it blank and 10% is used.

One rule to remember

Once offers exist in a category, the **Key** of a field cannot be changed. The key is the invisible name that ties the template to what suppliers have already typed. Rename it and every existing answer becomes an orphan. If you need a change, add a new field and retire the old one — the old answers stay readable.

4. Vendors and vendor logins

A **Vendor** is the supplier company record, under **Settings** → **Vendors**.

There are two ways offers get into the catalogue:

1. **Your staff enter them** — the common case. Most suppliers will never log in. Office Admin, Finance or Procurement enters the offer on the supplier's behalf.
2. **The supplier logs in themselves** — for regular suppliers you work with often. You create a user, give them the **Vendor** role, and link them to their vendor.

What a supplier can and cannot see

This is the part clients ask about most, so it is worth being exact.

A logged-in supplier sees:

- Its **own** offers, in every state — drafts, rejected, approved
- The spec template, so it knows what to fill in
- Its own orders and invoices

A logged-in supplier can **never** see:

- Another supplier's offers, prices or stock
- How its offer scored against a competitor
- Which offer you finally chose
- Your internal comments

How this is enforced

Not by hiding buttons. Every single database query for a supplier user has that supplier's identity built into it, and the system refuses to run the query at all if that identity is missing. Even if a supplier guessed the web address of a competitor's offer, the answer is "not found".

There are automatic tests that try to do exactly this — read a competitor's offer, edit it, compare against it — and each one must be refused before the software can be released.

5. Offers — what a supplier is selling

An **Offer** is one product, at one price, valid until one date. Not "Dell laptops" — one specific model at one specific price.

The dates are not optional

Every offer must have a **Price held until** date. This is deliberate.

Why

A price with no end date is a price nobody has promised. Six months later you raise an order at that figure, the supplier says "that was last year's rate", and the difference surfaces at invoice time as a mismatch nobody can explain.

With an end date, PioAssets simply refuses to let you choose an expired offer, and says so plainly: *"The vendor stopped honouring this price. Ask for a fresh offer."*

Offers show a live status you never have to update by hand:

Status	Meaning
Draft	Being written. Buyers cannot see it.
Awaiting review	Sent for internal checking
Available	Approved, in date, in stock — can be bought
Expiring soon	Within 7 days of its end date
Out of stock	Approved, but nothing left
Expired	Past its date. Cannot be chosen.
Rejected / Withdrawn	Turned down, or taken off the list

Available, Expiring soon, Out of stock and Expired are worked out from the date and the stock every time you look. Nobody has to remember to update them.

Pictures

One picture minimum, three maximum, 500 KB each, JPG / PNG / WEBP.

- **One minimum**, because a catalogue entry nobody can see the product in is not really a catalogue entry
- **Three maximum**, so the listing page stays a listing page
- The file type is decided by reading the **contents** of the file, not its name. Renaming a program file to `laptop.jpg` will not get it in.

Video

You may paste a normal YouTube link. Only the video's ID is stored — never supplier-supplied embed code, which is a well-known way to smuggle scripts into a page.

Review

Every offer starts as a **Draft** and must be approved before buyers see it.

A rejection **must** have a reason — a decision with no reason is one the supplier cannot act on. The supplier sees the reason and can fix and resubmit.

If a supplier later edits the price or specification of an approved offer, it goes back for review automatically. What was approved was those figures, not the entry.

6. Landed cost — the real price

The unit price is not what you pay. The **landed cost** is.

The formula, in order

```
Unit price
- Discount
= Value of goods
+ Shipping
+ Installation
= Taxable value
+ GST on the taxable value
+ Other charges
= LANDED COST (per unit)
```

Three points decide the number:

1. **GST is charged after the discount**, not before. You do not pay tax on money you were never charged.
2. **Shipping and installation are taxed with the goods**. Under GST these are part of the same composite supply, so they sit inside the taxable value.
3. **Other charges sit outside the GST base** — for things already taxed, or not taxable.

Worked example — a real laptop offer

ThinkPad T14 Gen 5, from Alpha Computers

	Amount
Unit price	₹1,08,000
Less discount	– ₹8,000
Value of goods	₹1,00,000
Shipping	+ ₹1,500
Taxable value	₹1,01,500
GST at 18%	+ ₹18,270
Landed cost per unit	₹1,19,770

Order 3 units and the total recorded is ₹3,59,310.

Note what would happen if GST were charged before the discount: 18% of ₹1,09,500 is ₹19,710 — you would over-state the cost by ₹1,440 on every single unit.

The landed cost is always worked out by PioAssets, on the server, and stored. It is never accepted from whoever is typing — a landed cost the sender supplies is a landed cost the sender chose.

7. Comparison — checking offers against what you need

Tick two or more offers in the catalogue and press **Compare**.

You then say what you actually need — for example *RAM at least 16 GB*, and tick **Must have**. Every offer is checked against every requirement, and each answer comes back as one of three results, **with the reason written next to it**.

The three results

Result	Meaning
Pass	Meets or beats what you asked for
Partial	Close, but not quite — a person should decide
Fail	Does not meet it, or the supplier never stated it

Worked example — three laptops, one requirement

You need: RAM at least 16 GB (Must have)

	EliteBook 645	ThinkPad T14	Latitude 5450
Landed cost	₹1,06,082	₹1,19,770	₹1,10,920
RAM offered	16 GB	16 GB	8 GB
Result	Pass	Pass	Fail
Reason	Meets the requirement	Meets the requirement	Under the requirement: 8 GB against 16 GB

The order shown is: EliteBook, ThinkPad, Latitude.

Look at the Latitude. At ₹1,10,920 it is cheaper than the ThinkPad, yet it is placed **last** — because it misses a Must have. A cheapest-first list would have put it second and somebody would have bought the wrong laptop.

The rule about blank answers

If a supplier never filled in a field, the result is **Fail**, and the reason says "Not stated by the vendor".

Why not treat it as Partial?

Because you would be giving a half-tick to a claim nobody ever made. "Worse than asked for" and "nobody told us" are different problems, and the buyer must be able to see which one they are looking at.

How offers are ordered

In this order, and price is deliberately last:

1. Offers that meet all **Must have** requirements come first
2. Then fewer failures
3. Then more passes

4. **Then** the cheaper one

Why price is last

Sort by price first and the comparison quietly becomes a cheapest-wins list — which is exactly the decision the buyer is supposed to be justifying.

Two things the comparison does not do

- **It never uses AI.** It is plain arithmetic, so any row can be reproduced by hand when Finance asks how a figure was reached.
- **Suppliers cannot see it.** How an offer scored against a competitor belongs to the buyer, not the seller. Employees cannot see it either, because it shows supplier pricing.

8. Selection — freezing the proof

When you choose an offer, PioAssets takes a **snapshot**: the price, the full breakdown, the specification, the warranty and the end date, exactly as they were on that day.

Why this matters

Suppose in March you choose a laptop at ₹1,19,770. In April the supplier raises the price to ₹1,35,000 — perfectly normal.

In September, an auditor asks why you paid what you paid. Without a snapshot, the catalogue now shows ₹1,35,000 and the record makes no sense. With a snapshot, the decision still shows the ₹1,19,770 that was true when it was made.

Choosing an offer is limited to Office Admin, Finance, Procurement Manager and Super Admin. Employees can raise requests, but **never see or enter pricing** — that rule runs through the whole system.

If you change your mind, undoing a selection keeps it as a dated record rather than erasing it. That a supplier was chosen and then dropped is exactly the kind of thing an audit asks about.

9. Quality check — the step that makes goods usable

When goods arrive, receiving records that a box turned up. **Quality check** records whether what was inside is fit to use — and it is the step that turns a received asset into an available one.

Open a purchase order, expand a receipt, and inspect each line. On mobile, tap the receipt on the order.

On an asset line, you tick the actual units

Not a number — the actual laptops, by tag and serial.

Worked example — 3 laptops arrive, 1 is damaged

Unit	Serial	Your action	Result
GRN-004360-1-1	SN-AAA-1	leave unticked	Becomes Available
GRN-004360-1-2	SN-BBB-2	tick	Becomes Retired (going back)
GRN-004360-1-3	SN-CCC-3	leave unticked	Becomes Available

Reason: "Screen cracked in transit". Result: **Partly passed**, 2 accepted, 1 rejected.

The count follows your ticking. You never type "1" as well — two ways of saying the same thing means one of them will eventually be wrong, and the system would then hold back an arbitrary laptop instead of the cracked one.

What happens to rejected goods

You must say which:

- **Back to the supplier** — the unit leaves your asset register
- **Keep, as damaged** — you keep it, marked damaged, for someone to decide

For stock (not individual assets), rejected quantity is taken **back off the shelf** automatically. It was counted in when received, and it is now waiting on the dock to go back — the shelf must not claim stock you do not have.

The rules the system will not bend

- Accepted + rejected must add up to what actually arrived. An inspection that loses count is worse than no inspection, because it looks authoritative.
 - A rejection must have a **reason** — otherwise the supplier cannot be held to it.
 - A line is inspected **once**. A second opinion has to be a deliberate act.
 - An asset somebody has already moved on is never dragged backwards by a late inspection.
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10. Who can do what

Action	Who
See the catalogue	Office Admin, Finance, Procurement, IT Admin, Super Admin, and suppliers (own offers only)
Add / edit offers	Office Admin, Finance, Procurement, Super Admin, and suppliers (own offers only)
Approve or reject an offer	Office Admin, Finance, Procurement, IT Admin, Super Admin
Edit spec templates	Office Admin, Finance, Procurement, IT Admin, Super Admin
Compare offers	Office Admin, Finance, Procurement, IT Admin, Super Admin
Choose an offer	Office Admin, Finance, Procurement, Super Admin
Quality check	Anyone who can receive goods

Three rules worth stating plainly:

1. **Employees never see supplier pricing.** They raise requests; they do not enter or view cost.
2. **Suppliers cannot edit the spec template.** They would be setting the questions they are marked on.
3. **Suppliers cannot review their own offers,** or anybody's.

11. Getting started — the order to do it in

1. **Add your suppliers** — Settings → Vendors
2. **Set up a spec template** for one type you buy often, say Laptop.
Four or five fields is plenty to begin with; you can add more later.
3. **Add two or three offers** of that type, so there is something to compare
4. **Try a comparison** — ask for something you genuinely need and see how the offers line up
5. **Only then,** if you want suppliers entering their own offers, create vendor logins

Step 2 is the one people skip, and everything else depends on it. With no template there is nothing to compare on, and the comparison screen will tell you so.

12. Common questions

We entered an offer but nobody can see it.

It is still a Draft. Add a picture, then send it for review, then approve it.

The system will not let us send an offer for review.

Either it has no picture, or a Required field in the template is blank. The message names the missing fields.

A supplier's price changed. Do we edit the old offer?

Edit it — it goes back for review automatically. Selections already made keep the old price, which is what you want.

Can we compare offers of different types?

Only on the questions they share. A laptop and a monitor are described by different things, so there is little common ground to compare on.

Why does a 32 GB laptop show "Exceeds" rather than just Pass?

So you can see you are being offered more than you asked for — sometimes that is worth paying for, sometimes it means the supplier misread the requirement.

We inspected the wrong line. Can we redo it?

Not by simply repeating it — that is deliberate. Contact your administrator, so that changing an inspection is a decision somebody takes, not an accident.

Prepared for TechPIO Services LLP. For any question on this document, contact Harry Singh · +91 98768 19230.